



Free and Open Source Tools for Research

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June 15, 2026

What is FOSS?

Definition

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- that is freely available (usually under a permissive license);
- has accessible source code.

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More restrictive definitions exist [\[1\]](#)!

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Philosophy of Free Software

The philosophy of free software can be encapsulated by *four essential freedoms* [2]:

1. to use the software.
2. to inspect and change the software.
3. to share copies of the original software.
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The freedoms associated with the use of free software are given legal weight by various **licenses**, classified as *copyleft* or *permissive* [3].

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Despite good reasons to use them, free and open source tools are not always a good idea. You need to be mindful of the following:

- Use tools that work well with what your collaborators are using.
- FOSS tools are often not as polished as their proprietary counterparts.
- Security concerns.

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Tools

Types of Tools

- There is a large selection of open source tools available, including **coding** and **writing**.
- One of the most fundamental tools is a text editor.
- Even though you start with text, output is not necessarily just a text file!

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Python Code for Statistics

```
1 import numpy as np
2 import seaborn as sns
3 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
4 sns.set_theme(style="dark")
5
6 # Simulate data from a bivariate Gaussian
7 n = 10000
8 mean = [0, 0]
9 cov = [(2, .4), (.4, .2)]
10 rng = np.random.RandomState(0)
11 x, y = rng.multivariate_normal(mean, cov, n).T
12
13 # Draw a combo histogram and scatterplot with density
    contours
14 f, ax = plt.subplots(figsize=(6, 6))
15 sns.scatterplot(x=x, y=y, s=5, color=".15")
16 sns.histplot(x=x, y=y, bins=50, pthresh=.1, cmap="mako")
17 sns.kdeplot(x=x, y=y, levels=5, color="w", linewidths=1)
```

Listing 1: Example Python code for statistical visualization

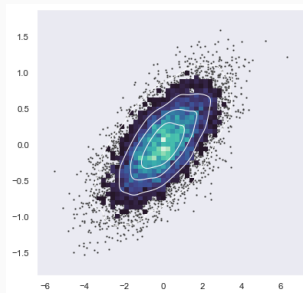


Figure 1: Data visualization produced by Listing 1

IDE vs. Text Editor

- When using programming languages, you will need a program to interact with the language.
- There is often a choice between an *integrated development environment* (IDE) and a text editor.
- Open source IDEs: RStudio, Spyder, Octave (GUI).
- Open source text editors: VSCode (new school), Vi(m) and Emacs (very old school).

General or specific language support

IDEs are tailored to specific languages (such as RStudio). Text editors tend to be more multi-purpose.

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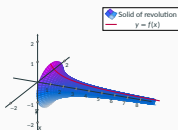


Figure 2: A PGFPlots drawing

- matplotlib
- pandas
- TikZ/PGFPlots
- Inkscape

Composability Again

- The tools mentioned so far are not mutually exclusive!
- These tools have specific purposes, but can be chained together to form a powerful workflow.

Solving a Math Problem

The expanded form of $(x - 3)^5$ is
 $x^5 - 15x^4 + 90x^3 - 270x^2 + 405x - 243.$

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Sharing Your Work

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References

- [1] *Open Source - GNU Project - Free Software Foundation (FSF).* July 3, 2007. URL:
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